



Nutrition Fundamentals — Quick Start Guide

The 3 Science-Based Rules That Actually Change Your Body

By Adriano | Transform Method — **Bonus Guide**

Disclaimer: This guide presents a science-based educational framework and is for informational purposes only. It is not a substitute for individualized medical or nutritional advice. The author is a certified nutrition and change psychology coach (Precision Nutrition), not a licensed dietitian or physician. Consult a healthcare professional before making any significant dietary change.

Why Most Nutrition Advice Fails You

We live in the most information-rich era in human history. And yet obesity rates have tripled since 1975. In the United States, 42% of adults are obese; in Brazil, the rate has doubled in the last 20 years.

This is the nutrition paradox: **more information, worse outcomes**. Why? Because the nutrition industry doesn't profit from simplicity — it profits from confusion. One decade fat is the villain (low-fat era), the next it's carbs (low-carb era), then gluten, then lectins, then seed oils. Each trend creates a new market. New books. New supplements. New gurus. But the fundamentals never change.

Here's what most nutrition guides won't tell you: **you probably already know 80% of this**. Eat enough protein. Eat real food. Be consistent. There's no shortcut. This guide gives you the three rules that actually move the needle — and the exact math to apply them to your body.

Rule 1: Energy Balance Decides Everything

Every diet that works, works through one mechanism: **energy balance**. Eating more than you burn means weight gain; eating less means weight loss; eating equal means maintenance. This isn't opinion — it's the First Law of Thermodynamics applied to human metabolism.

Your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE) breaks down into: **Basal Metabolic Rate** (60-70%, energy for basic physiological function), **Thermic Effect of Food** (10%, energy spent digesting), **Exercise Activity** (5-10%, structured training), and **Non-Exercise Activity (NEAT)** (15-30%, everything else — the most variable component, and the one that quietly sabotages diets). When you cut calories, your body unconsciously reduces NEAT — you take the elevator more, fidget less, move slower — which can silently erase 200-500 kcal/day of your deficit. **Solution:** track daily steps (target 8,000-10,000) to keep NEAT from working against you.

Rule 2: Protein Is Non-Negotiable

Protein is the single highest-leverage macronutrient for body transformation, because it: preserves muscle during a deficit (2.0-2.4g/kg protects 95%+ of lean mass while losing fat), controls hunger (the most satiating macronutrient, cutting hunger by ~60% versus carbs or fat), and costs more calories to digest than any other macro (20-30% of its own calories, versus 0-3% for fat).

How much you need:

Goal	Protein (per lb)	Protein (per kg)
Sedentary adult	0.36 g/lb	0.8 g/kg
Active adult	0.73-1.0 g/lb	1.6-2.2 g/kg
Fat loss	0.9-1.2 g/lb	2.0-2.4 g/kg
Muscle gain	0.73-1.0 g/lb	1.6-2.2 g/kg

Example: a 176 lb (80kg) man on a fat-loss goal needs about 176g protein/day — spread across 4 meals, that's roughly 44g per meal (a palm-sized portion of chicken, fish, or lean beef, or 1.5 scoops of whey).

Carbs and fat matter too — carbs fuel training and protect your hormones, fat is essential for testosterone, estrogen, and vitamin absorption — but protein is the macro that decides whether the weight you lose is fat or muscle.

Carbs and Fat: The Other Two Levers



Protein decides whether you lose fat or muscle. Carbs and fat decide how well you perform and feel while you do it.

Carbs are your primary fuel for high-intensity training, stored as glycogen in muscle and liver. Cutting them too hard tanks performance, mood, and cognitive function — the brain alone burns ~120g of glucose a day. How much you need scales with activity: roughly 2-3g/kg if you're sedentary, up to 8-10g/kg if you train twice a day. There's no metabolic magic to low-carb — a meta-analysis of 32 studies found identical fat loss between low-carb and low-fat diets at equal calories. It works for some people purely because it makes calorie control easier, not because carbs are toxic.

Fat is essential, not optional: dietary cholesterol is the building block for testosterone, estrogen, and cortisol, and chronically low fat intake (under ~0.5g/kg) can suppress testosterone by 10-15%. Aim for at least 0.5g/kg, ideally 0.8-1.2g/kg, prioritizing olive oil, avocado, nuts, and fatty fish over fried and processed sources.

Putting it together: set protein first (it's non-negotiable), set fat second (the minimum for hormonal health), and let carbs fill whatever calories remain. That's the entire macro-split decision — no app or influencer formula needed.

Rule 3: Calculate, Don't Guess

Step 1 — Basal Metabolic Rate (Mifflin-St Jeor):

Men: $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) + 5$

Women: $BMR = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age}) - 161$

Step 2 — TDEE: multiply BMR by your activity factor (sedentary $\times 1.2$ · lightly active $\times 1.375$ · moderately active $\times 1.55$ · very active $\times 1.725$).

Step 3 — Set your target: fat loss = TDEE – 500 kcal ($\approx 0.5\text{kg/week}$, sustainable); muscle gain = TDEE + 300-500 kcal; maintenance = TDEE.

Example: 30-year-old male, 80kg, 180cm, training 4x/week: $BMR = 1,780 \text{ kcal} \rightarrow TDEE = 1,780 \times 1.55 = \mathbf{2,759 \text{ kcal/day}} \rightarrow \text{fat-loss target} = \mathbf{2,259 \text{ kcal/day}}$, with protein set first (176g), fat second (80g), and carbs filling the rest (209g).

Use the Transform Method calculator at transform-method-ruby.vercel.app/calculator to automate this — or use the formulas above manually.

What a Day of Eating Actually Looks Like

Here's the 2,259 kcal / 176g protein target from the example above, built into a real day of food:

Meal	Foods	Macros
Breakfast	3 whole eggs + 2 slices whole wheat toast + 1 banana	27g protein, 57g carbs, 15g fat
Lunch	150g chicken breast + 200g white rice + 100g broccoli + 1 tbsp olive oil	52g protein, 63g carbs, 14g fat
Snack	1 scoop whey protein + 1 apple + 1 tbsp peanut butter	29g protein, 21g carbs, 8g fat
Dinner	180g salmon + 250g sweet potato + 150g mixed vegetables + 1 tbsp olive oil	46g protein, 62g carbs, 32g fat

Nothing exotic, no powders required beyond a scoop of whey — just protein at every meal, a starch, and a vegetable. Swap the specific foods for whatever fits your culture and budget; the structure is what matters.

Making It Stick: The 80/20 Rule

The "if it fits your macros" debate misses the point: for pure fat loss, hitting your numbers is what matters — but for satiety, health, and sustainability, food quality matters too. The fix isn't perfection, it's a ratio: **80% of your diet** from whole, minimally processed foods (lean proteins, whole grains, fruits and vegetables, healthy fats), and **20% flexible** — treats, social meals, whatever you want, within your calorie budget. This is what prevents the all-or-nothing cycle that kills most diets by week three.

Track for 4-8 weeks to learn real portion sizes (a food scale beats guessing every time — a tablespoon of olive oil is 120 kcal, easy to miss), then transition to intuitive eating once you can maintain results without logging everything.

The 3 Mistakes That Quietly Stall Progress



- 1 **Underestimating intake:** "bites," cooking oil, sauces, and drinks rarely get logged, but a tablespoon of olive oil alone is 120 kcal — log everything for 2 weeks, even the small stuff, before concluding a plan "isn't working"
- 2 **Overestimating activity:** fitness trackers and gym machines commonly overestimate calories burned by 20-30% — treat those numbers as a rough guide, not a budget to spend
- 3 **Quitting at the first plateau:** 2-3 weeks with no movement on the scale isn't failure, it's biology (water retention, metabolic adaptation, or a slightly loose deficit) — the fix is a small adjustment (100-200 kcal, or a diet break at maintenance for a week), not starting over from scratch

The Real Reason Diets Fail (It's Not What You Think)

Everything above is, in practice, the basic consensus taught in any serious evidence-based nutrition course. There's no hidden secret. And yet most people who read exactly this don't sustain the change. Why?

The answer isn't more nutrition information. It's how we deal with hunger and cravings in the moment they show up. Much of the eating that happens outside of real hunger isn't a failure of discipline — it's a learned reward loop: a trigger (stress, boredom) leads to a craving, which leads to eating, which brings relief, which reinforces the loop. Willpower alone tends to lose to a reward system that's already automated.

The alternative is **curiosity instead of willpower**. Next time a craving shows up outside of real hunger: pause for 60 seconds, notice where it shows up in your body, and just observe it without judgment or immediately acting on it. Most of the time, its intensity rises, peaks, and falls on its own — without you having to "beat" anything. This one shift — from suppressing or giving in, to observing — is the actual skill that determines whether year two looks different from year one.

Supplements: What's Actually Worth Your Money

Supplements are a \$50 billion industry built almost entirely on marketing, not evidence. Before spending on anything, know that supplements are exactly what the name says: they supplement a diet that's already dialed in. No pill or powder outperforms hitting your protein target and sleeping enough.



That said, a short list has genuine research behind it:

Whey or plant protein: not magic, just convenient — the fastest way to close a protein gap when whole food isn't practical. Any brand that discloses a third-party test (Informed Sport or NSF Certified for Sport) is a safe pick.

Creatine monohydrate: the single most-studied supplement in sports nutrition, with a strong safety record across decades of trials. 3-5g daily, any time of day, supports strength and lean mass — it's cheap and it works.

Vitamin D: worth checking with a blood test if you get limited sun exposure; deficiency is common and affects hormone production and recovery.

Everything else: fat burners, BCAAs (redundant if your protein intake is already adequate), detox teas, and most "testosterone boosters" have weak or no evidence behind their claims at the doses sold. Save the money and put it toward real food.

A Sample Grocery List to Keep On Hand

Stock these categories and building a day of eating like the example above becomes almost automatic — no recipes required, just combinations.

Protein: eggs, chicken breast, lean ground beef, canned tuna or salmon, whey or plant protein powder, Greek yogurt or cottage cheese, tofu or tempeh (plant-based option).

Carbohydrates: rice (white or brown), oats, potatoes and sweet potatoes, whole-grain bread, fruit (bananas, apples, berries), beans and lentils (protein + carb combo).

Fats: olive oil, avocado, nuts and nut butters, whole eggs, fatty fish (salmon, sardines).

Vegetables: whatever is cheapest and in season — frozen vegetables retain nearly identical nutrient content to fresh and cost less, so don't skip the freezer aisle out of a "fresh is better" assumption not supported by the evidence.

Keep the list boring and repeatable. The people who sustain results aren't the ones with the most creative meal plan — they're the ones who never have to think hard about what to eat, because the same reliable staples are always in the kitchen.

Frequently Asked Questions



Do I need to eat breakfast?: no — meal timing and frequency have minimal effect on fat loss once total daily calories and protein are controlled. Eat breakfast if it helps you feel and perform better; skip it if it doesn't. Neither choice has a metabolic advantage on its own.

Is intermittent fasting better for fat loss?: no better or worse than any other eating pattern at equal calories — its main benefit for some people is that a smaller eating window makes calorie control easier, not that fasting itself burns more fat.

How fast should I expect to see results?: the scale can move within the first 1-2 weeks (partly water weight), but visible body composition change typically takes 4-6 weeks of consistency to notice, and 8-12 weeks to see clearly in photos. Patience is a skill, not a personality trait — and it's trainable.

What if I have a bad week?: one inconsistent week changes almost nothing over a 12-week arc. What derails progress isn't a single bad week — it's treating it as proof the plan failed and quitting instead of just returning to the plan at the next meal.

Your First 7 Days: A Simple Action Plan

Reading this guide changes nothing on its own. Here's how to turn it into action this week, one step at a time instead of all at once:

Day 1: calculate your TDEE and fat-loss target using Rule 3 above (or the calculator link). Write the number down somewhere you'll see it daily.

Day 2: calculate your protein target from the table in Rule 2, and check it against what you ate yesterday. Most people are surprised by the gap.

Day 3: pick 3 protein sources and 3 carb sources you actually enjoy from the grocery list, and put them on this week's shopping list. Don't overhaul everything — just make sure protein is available at every meal.

Day 4: log everything you eat for one full day, including oils, sauces, and drinks. Don't change anything yet — just see where you actually stand.

Day 5: build one meal using the "Day of Eating" template above — a protein, a starch, a vegetable, portioned to your numbers.

Day 6: review Days 1-5. Are you consistently near your protein target? Is logging becoming automatic? Adjust portions, not the whole plan.



Day 7: repeat the curiosity exercise from "The Real Reason Diets Fail" the next time a craving shows up outside of real hunger, and notice what happens when you observe instead of react.

Seven days won't transform your body. But it will prove the framework works in your actual life — which is the only thing that predicts whether you'll still be doing this in six months.

Ready to Build Your Full Plan?

This guide covers the fundamentals — but a real transformation needs a plan built around your body, your schedule, and your life, plus the accountability to actually follow through.

Join the Transform Method mentorship and get weekly 1-on-1 coaching, a personalized nutrition and training plan, and a private accountability system. **Join at the quarterly plan or above and every ebook in the Transform Method library — including this one's full Complete Guide — comes included, along with every future update, at no extra cost.**

Link in bio.

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